Route 66 Turns 100: America's Most Famous Road

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America's famous road turned 100 years old. Route 66 was built in 1926. It runs from Chicago to Santa Monica, California more than 2,000 miles through eight states.

Writer John Steinbeck gave the road its **nickname**, 'the Mother Road.' His 1939 book The Grapes of Wrath told the story of families driving west on Route 66 during the **Dust Bowl**, when dust storms in the 1930s pushed families off their farms. The book won a **Pulitzer Prize**.

The road has a song and a screen life, too. Bobby Troup wrote '(Get Your Kicks on) Route 66' in 1946, and Nat King Cole made it a hit. A TV show called Route 66 followed two friends driving across America, the 1969 movie Easy Rider sent three travelers down the road on **motorcycles**, and Pixar's 2006 movie Cars told its story in Radiator Springs, a town on Route 66.

The road stopped being a **federal highway** in 1985, but people love it. Route 66 expert Michael Wallis says the road is all about **adventure** and a peek at a dream.

Word Treasure

nickname -- A special name people use instead of the real one.
Dust Bowl -- A time in the 1930s when big dust storms ruined farms in America.
Pulitzer Prize -- A famous award given for great books and writing.
federal highway -- A big road built and cared for by the country's government.
adventure -- An exciting trip or journey full of new things to see and do.
motorcycles -- Two-wheeled vehicles with engines that people ride.

Background you need

Route 66 is a famous road that runs across America from Chicago to Santa Monica, California, passing through eight states.

Long ago, many families drove west on it to find new homes and work after dust storms pushed them off their farms.

Today people still love the road for its adventure, its small towns, and the songs and movies it inspired.

Break it down

WHO: Writer John Steinbeck, songwriter Bobby Troup, singer Nat King Cole, Route 66 expert Michael Wallis, and the families who drove west during the Dust Bowl.

WHAT: A road built in 1926 marked its 100th birthday and is still celebrated in books, songs, a TV show, and movies.

WHERE: From Chicago to Santa Monica, California, running more than 2,000 miles through eight states.

WHY: People love the road because it stands for adventure and a peek at a dream, and its stories keep it famous even though it stopped being a federal highway in 1985.

Why it matters

A family road trip can turn into a real-life adventure, just like the stories, songs, and movies about Route 66 show.

Test what you remember

1. In what year was Route 66 built?

- (A) 1939
- (B) 1926
- (C) 1985
- (D) 1946

2. Which two cities are at the two ends of Route 66?

- (A) New York and Los Angeles
- (B) Chicago and Santa Monica, California
- (C) St. Louis and Santa Monica, California
- (D) Chicago and Las Vegas

3. Who gave Route 66 its nickname the Mother Road?

- (A) Bobby Troup
- (B) John Steinbeck
- (C) Nat King Cole
- (D) Michael Wallis

4. What story did John Steinbeck's book The Grapes of Wrath tell?

- (A) The story of two friends driving across America
- (B) The story of three travelers riding motorcycles
- (C) The story of families driving west on Route 66 during the Dust Bowl
- (D) The story of a town called Radiator Springs

5. Who wrote the song (Get Your Kicks on) Route 66?

- (A) John Steinbeck
- (B) Pixar
- (C) Nat King Cole
- (D) Bobby Troup

6. Which movie told Route 66's story in Radiator Springs?

- (A) Easy Rider
- (B) The Grapes of Wrath
- (C) Route 66
- (D) Cars

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Route 66 expert Michael Wallis: The road is all about adventure -- and a peek at a dream.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):